

| By Priya Sahgal |

Look what we have got. Once an accidental prime minister who was least political, he is now a hot political item in one of democracy's chaotic bazaars. And hard-selling Brand Manmohan Singh is the longest surviving political dynasty of the East, headed by Our Lady of Deliverance at 10 Janpath. Five years ago, Sonia Gandhi had to just make him prime minister—a prerogative of the Paramount Leader which she exercised with such maudlin aplomb. This time, she has to sell a prime minister, and maybe he is the only thing worth selling for her and the party. The Family—Reluctant Son, Cool Daughter and Holy Mother—is wowing captive clients with its sales pitch. The prime minister has now become the campaign. The Choice. Not bad for a man who has contested only once to the Lok Sabha—and that too to lose.

For once, he is out there in the vanguard, as a saviour and a slogan. To realise the enormity of this singular moment in his career, we have to return to his back story. The story of a dutiful technocrat who was luckier than the rest. A trustworthy, result-oriented workaholic who flourished in the reassuring shadow of a politically shrewd mentor. From the cozy anonymity of filedom, it was Narasimha Rao who brought him to the limelight of power as finance minister, a position that would earn him the sobriquet of the

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